How Does Female Leadership Relate to Wage–Productivity Gaps in Colombia?

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Abstract

This study examines whether female leadership is associated with lower labor monopsony power in Colombian manufacturing firms. In labor markets with frictions such as search costs, limited mobility, and employer concentration, firms may exercise monopsony power and pay wages below workers' marginal productivity, generating wage-productivity gaps known as labor markdowns.

While these distortions arise from structural labor market frictions, firms differ substantially in how they exercise wage-setting power. Management decisions play an important role in shaping wage-setting practices and employment policies, suggesting that leadership characteristics may influence the extent to which firms exploit monopsony power. Prior research suggests that female leaders may adopt organizational practices that place greater weight on worker welfare, employment stability, and equitable compensation.

Using firm-level data from the Colombian Manufacturing Survey (1998-2024), I construct firm-level labor markdowns and relate them to the share of firm ownership held by women using regressions that control for firm and industry characteristics. Markdown estimates are derived from production-function methods that recover labor elasticities and compare the marginal revenue product of labor to wages.

The results show a negative association between female ownership shares and labor markdowns. These findings suggest that leadership composition may influence firms' wage-setting behavior and have implications for policies promoting greater female representation in firm leadership in emerging economies.

JEL Classification: D43, D63, J16,J42,J7, M12, M52

Keywords: female leadership, labor market power, wage–productivity gap, markdowns, monopsony, Colombia

1 Introduction

Standard microeconomic theory predicts that in competitive labor markets wages equal workers' marginal products. Under this benchmark, firms act as wage takers, workers can freely move across jobs, and compensation accurately reflects productivity. Departures from this framework arise when firms possess wage-setting power, as in monopsonistic labor markets where employers face upward-sloping labor supply curves (Robinson, 1969). A growing literature shows that labor markets are often characterized by frictions such as search costs (Card, 2022; Azar et al., 2019; Lentz and Mortensen, 2010; Moscarini and Postel-Vinay, 2010; Manning, 2021), limited job mobility (Caldwell and Danieli, 2024; Schubert et al., 2025; Starr et al., 2021; McAdams, 2019), and employer concentration (Azar et al., 2017; Benmelech et al., 2018; Rinz, 2022). These frictions grant firms wage-setting power, allowing them to pay wages below workers' marginal productivity and generating a wage-productivity gap commonly referred to as a labor markdown.

Evidence suggests that such distortions are particularly pronounced in developing and emerging economies, where labor market frictions tend to be stronger. In Latin America and the Caribbean, workers receive roughly half of the value they generate on average, compared to about 65 percent in the United States and 81 percent in advanced economies (Alviarez et al., 2025). For Colombia, Amodio and de Roux, 2024 estimate a labor supply elasticity of 2.5, implying that workers produce approximately 40 percent more than they earn.

While monopsony power arises from structural features of labor markets, firms differ substantially in how they exercise wage-setting power. Management decisions shape wage-setting practices, organizational culture, and employment policies, suggesting that firm leadership may influence the extent to which monopsony power is exercised. This paper examines whether leadership characteristics—specifically gender composition—are systematically associated with differences in labor market power.

In particular, I investigate whether firms with greater female ownership exhibit lower labor markdowns than firms primarily owned by men. Prior research suggests that female leaders may adopt management styles that place greater weight on worker welfare and employment stability (Matsa and Miller, 2013; Tunyi et al., 2023), interpret productivity signals differently (Flabbi et al., 2017; Chen et al., 2019), or influence corporate decision-making in ways that reduce wage distortions (Levi et al., 2014; Flabbi et al., 2019). Moreover, labor market power has been shown to affect women more strongly than men (Sharma, 2023), raising the possibility that female leadership may mitigate gender-specific wage distortions within firms. If female leaders place relatively greater weight on worker welfare, long-term employment relationships, or equitable compensation, firms they lead may exercise monop-

sony power less aggressively, resulting in lower labor markdowns.

To examine this relationship, I use firm-level data from the Colombian Manufacturing Survey (EAM, from its Spanish initials) collected by the National Department of Statistics of Colombia (Departamento Administrativo Nacional de Estadística (DANE), n.d.). I estimate labor markdowns following the production-function methodology developed by Yeh et al., 2022. Specifically, markdowns are calculated using elasticities derived from a Cobb-Douglas revenue production function, with the wage bill used as the measure of labor input. Following Ackerberg et al., 2015, estimates of the revenue function elasticity allow the marginal revenue product of labor to be computed and compared to the average wage paid by the firm, yielding a firm-level wage markdown. This is the same methodology used by the Inter-American Development Bank in its Development in the Americas (DIA) 2025 report and the CompeteLAC dataset for markdown estimation. I then estimate regressions relating firm-level labor markdowns to the share of firm ownership held by women, controlling for observable firm and industry characteristics.

Preliminary evidence using industry-level markdowns estimated by Inter-American Development Bank, 2025 suggests a negative relationship between female ownership and labor markdowns, although the estimates are imprecise. Ongoing work will extend the analysis to firm-level markdowns and examine whether the relationship varies with labor market concentration and productivity differences across firms.

2 Literature Review

Table 1: Summary of Related Literature

Paper	**Topic**	**Data**	**Main Finding**
Azar, Marinescu & Steinbaum (2017)	Labor market concentration	U.S. labor markets	Higher employer concentration is associated with lower wages, suggesting firms exercise monopsony power.
Benmelech, Bergman & Kim (2018)	Employer concentration	U.S. manufacturing	More concentrated labor markets are linked to lower wages and reduced worker bargaining power.
Yeh, Macaluso & Hershbein (2022)	Labor markdown estimation	U.S. firms	Workers are paid below their marginal revenue product, indicating widespread labor market power.
Amodio & de Roux (2024)	Labor market power	Colombian manufacturing plants	Low labor supply elasticities imply significant wage-productivity gaps in Colombian firms.
Matsa & Miller (2013)	Female leadership	Corporate boards	Female leaders tend to emphasize employment stability and worker retention.
Flabbi et al. (2019)	Female executives	Firm-level data	Female leadership influences wage-setting and gender gaps within firms.

3 Economic Theory

This paper studies whether differences in ownership structure are associated with differences in firms' labor market power. The relevant theoretical framework combines imperfect competition in the product market with monopsony power in the labor market. On the output side, firms may charge a price above marginal cost, generating a markup. On the input side,

firms may pay wages below the marginal revenue product of labor, generating a markdown. The empirical objective is therefore to recover firm-level wedges from the production side of the firm and then examine whether these wedges vary systematically with the share of female ownership.

A useful starting point is the benchmark case of a competitive labor market. If firms are wage takers, they hire labor up to the point where the wage equals the marginal revenue product of labor. Graphically, labor demand is given by the marginal revenue product schedule, while labor supply to the firm is horizontal at the market wage. Under monopsony, by contrast, the firm faces an upward-sloping labor supply curve. Hiring an additional worker requires raising the wage not only for the marginal worker but, when wages are set uniformly, for inframarginal workers as well. As a result, the marginal expenditure on labor lies above the labor supply curve, and the profit-maximizing firm chooses employment where marginal revenue product equals marginal expenditure, not the wage itself. This implies lower employment and a lower wage than under perfect competition, and creates a gap between the wage and the marginal revenue product of labor. That gap is the central object of interest in this paper.

Formally, let firm i in year t produce output according to the production function

$$Q_{it} = F\left(L_{it}, K_{it}, M_{it}, \omega_{it}\right), \tag{1}$$

where L_{it} denotes labor, K_{it} capital, M_{it} materials, and ω_{it} firm-specific productivity. This setup follows the production approach to market power measurement developed by De Loecker and Warzynski and extended in De Loecker, Eeckhout, and Unger, where output elasticities are recovered from the estimated production function and combined with observed expenditure shares.

In the empirical implementation, I use a translog specification estimated separately by 4-digit manufacturing sector. The translog form is flexible and allows output elasticities to vary across firms and over time as a function of input use:

$$\begin{aligned} q_{it} = {} & \beta_0 + \beta_K k_{it} + \beta_L l_{it} + \beta_M m_{it} + \beta_{KK} k_{it}^2 + \beta_{LL} l_{it}^2 + \beta_{MM} m_{it}^2 \\ & + \beta_{KL} k_{it} l_{it} + \beta_{KM} k_{it} m_{it} + \beta_{LM} l_{it} m_{it} + \omega_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}, \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

where lower-case letters denote logs. The term ω_{it} captures productivity observed by the firm but not by the econometrician, while ε_{it} is an i.i.d. shock or measurement error. This specification is consistent with the production approach in De Loecker and Eeckhout, where the key empirical ingredient is the output elasticity of a variable input.

The code implements this production function sector by sector using a cascade procedure.

The preferred specification is a 10-parameter translog GMM estimator at the 4-digit sector level. When that specification is not feasible because of convergence or singularity issues, the code falls back sequentially to a Cobb-Douglas ACF-style GMM specification, then to an OLS translog plug-in, and finally to 2-digit sector median elasticities. This strategy prioritizes flexible, firm-varying elasticities whenever the data support them, while preserving coverage across smaller sectors.

The logic of the production approach begins from the firm's conditional cost minimization problem. Holding output fixed and taking input prices as given, the firm chooses variable inputs to minimize total cost:

$$\min_{L_{it},M_{it}} \; w_{it}L_{it} + p_{it}^{M}M_{it} + r_{it}K_{it} \quad \text{s.t.} \quad Q_{it} = F(L_{it}, K_{it}, M_{it}, \omega_{it}), \tag{3}$$

where w_{it} is the wage, p_{it}^{M} is the price of materials, and r_{it} is the user cost of capital. Since capital is quasi-fixed within the period, the relevant within-period choice concerns the flexible inputs, especially materials and labor. This timing assumption is central in the production approach: variable inputs adjust within the period, while capital is subject to adjustment frictions.

The associated Lagrangian is

$$\mathcal{L}_{it} = w_{it}L_{it} + p_{it}^{M}M_{it} + r_{it}K_{it} - \lambda_{it}\left[F(L_{it}, K_{it}, M_{it}, \omega_{it}) - Q_{it}\right]. \tag{4}$$

Here λ_{it} is the Lagrange multiplier on the production constraint and has the interpretation of marginal cost. In the De Loecker production framework, the markup is defined as price over marginal cost, $\mu_{it} = P_{it}/\lambda_{it}$. :contentReference[oaicite:4]index=4

Taking first-order conditions with respect to a flexible input V_{it} gives

$$P_{it}^{V} = \lambda_{it}\frac{\partial F(\cdot)}{\partial V_{it}}. \tag{5}$$

Multiplying both sides by V_{it}/Q_{it} and rearranging yields

$$\theta_{it}^{V} \equiv \frac{\partial F(\cdot)}{\partial V_{it}}\frac{V_{it}}{Q_{it}} = \frac{1}{\lambda_{it}}\frac{P_{it}^{V}V_{it}}{Q_{it}}, \tag{6}$$

where θ_{it}^{V} is the output elasticity of input V. Substituting $\lambda_{it} = P_{it}/\mu_{it}$ gives the standard production-approach markup formula:

$$\mu_{it} = \theta_{it}^{V}\frac{P_{it}Q_{it}}{P_{it}^{V}V_{it}}. \tag{7}$$

This expression shows that the markup can be recovered from two objects: the output elasticity of a flexible input and that input's expenditure share in revenue. This is the key insight of the production approach in De Loecker and Warzynski and in De Loecker, Eeckhout, and Unger.

In this paper, materials are used as the benchmark flexible input for markup estimation. The reason is both conceptual and practical. Conceptually, materials are more likely than labor to satisfy the within-period flexibility assumption. Practically, the code estimates firm-year output elasticities for materials, labor, and capital from the translog production function, but the markup is recovered using the materials first-order condition. Let α_{it}^M denote the expenditure share of materials in revenue:

$$\alpha_{it}^M = \frac{p_{it}^M M_{it}}{P_{it} Q_{it}}. \tag{8}$$

Then the firm-level markup is

$$\mu_{it} = \frac{\theta_{it}^M}{\alpha_{it}^M}. \tag{9}$$

The translog specification implies that output elasticities vary across firms and over time. For example, under the estimated translog technology, the labor elasticity is

$$\theta_{it}^L = \beta_L + 2\beta_{LL} l_{it} + \beta_{KL} k_{it} + \beta_{LM} m_{it}, \tag{10}$$

with analogous expressions for θ_{it}^K and θ_{it}^M. This is exactly how the code constructs the elasticities after estimating the translog coefficients: the gradient of the production function is evaluated at each firm's observed input bundle. As a result, the preferred Tier 1 and Tier 3 procedures generate firm-year-varying elasticities, while the fallback Cobb-Douglas specification generates sector-level constant elasticities.

The markdown requires a different first-order condition because labor may not be purchased competitively. If the firm faces an upward-sloping labor supply curve, then the relevant marginal labor cost is not the wage itself but the marginal expenditure on labor. Let the inverse labor supply to the firm be $w_{it}(L_{it})$. The firm's profit-maximization problem on the labor margin implies

$$MR_{it} \frac{\partial F(\cdot)}{\partial L_{it}} = w_{it}(L_{it}) + \frac{\partial w_{it}(L_{it})}{\partial L_{it}} L_{it}, \tag{11}$$

where MR_{it} is marginal revenue. Defining the firm-specific labor supply elasticity as

$$\varepsilon_{it}^L = \frac{\partial L_{it}}{\partial w_{it}} \frac{w_{it}}{L_{it}}, \tag{12}$$

the marginal expenditure on labor can be written as

$$ME_{it}^{L} = w_{it}\left(1 + \frac{1}{\varepsilon_{it}^{L}}\right). \tag{13}$$

Hence monopsony implies

$$MRPL_{it} = w_{it}\left(1 + \frac{1}{\varepsilon_{it}^{L}}\right), \tag{14}$$

so that the wage lies below the marginal revenue product whenever labor supply is upward sloping.

It is convenient to summarize this wedge with a markdown parameter. I define the markdown as the ratio of the wage to the marginal revenue product of labor:

$$\nu_{it} = \frac{w_{it}}{MRPL_{it}} = \frac{\varepsilon_{it}^{L}}{1 + \varepsilon_{it}^{L}}, \tag{15}$$

so that $\nu_{it} = 1$ under perfect competition in the labor market and $\nu_{it} < 1$ under monopsony. Equivalently, one can work with the inverse markdown, $MRPL_{it}/w_{it}$, which exceeds one when firms have labor market power. The two measures contain the same information; they differ only by normalization.

To express the markdown in terms of observables, note that

$$MRPL_{it} = \frac{P_{it}}{\mu_{it}} \frac{\partial F(\cdot)}{\partial L_{it}}, \tag{16}$$

because marginal revenue equals price divided by the markup. Multiplying by $L_{it}/(P_{it}Q_{it})$ yields

$$\frac{MRPL_{it}L_{it}}{P_{it}Q_{it}} = \frac{\theta_{it}^{L}}{\mu_{it}}. \tag{17}$$

Let $\alpha_{it}^{L} = \frac{w_{it}L_{it}}{P_{it}Q_{it}}$ denote labor's revenue share. Then the markdown can be written as

$$\nu_{it} = \frac{w_{it}}{MRPL_{it}} = \frac{\mu_{it}\alpha_{it}^{L}}{\theta_{it}^{L}}. \tag{18}$$

Substituting the materials-based markup estimate gives

$$\nu_{it} = \frac{\theta_{it}^{M}}{\alpha_{it}^{M}} \cdot \frac{\alpha_{it}^{L}}{\theta_{it}^{L}} = \frac{\theta_{it}^{M}\alpha_{it}^{L}}{\alpha_{it}^{M}\theta_{it}^{L}}. \tag{19}$$

This expression makes the empirical strategy transparent. The markdown is identified from four objects: the output elasticity of materials, the output elasticity of labor, the materials

expenditure share in revenue, and the labor expenditure share in revenue. The first two come from the estimated production function; the latter two come directly from the data.

This framework also clarifies the interpretation of the dependent variable used in the empirical analysis. Higher markdown power corresponds to a larger gap between the marginal revenue product of labor and the wage paid by the firm. In the normalization above, this means a lower value of ν_{it}. If instead the empirical specification uses the inverse ratio, $MRPL_{it}/w_{it}$, then greater labor market power corresponds to a higher value. In either case, the object measures the extent to which firms deviate from the competitive benchmark in the labor market.

Finally, this theoretical framework motivates the expected relationship between ownership structure and labor market outcomes. If female ownership is associated with differences in pay-setting behavior, bargaining, workplace organization, or firms' labor supply elasticities, then it may also be associated with differences in markdowns. The econometric analysis therefore tests whether firms with a higher female ownership share exhibit systematically different labor wedges after controlling for sector, region, productivity, year, and firm size.

4 Data

This paper uses firm-level data from the Annual Manufacturing Survey (Encuesta Anual Manufacturera, EAM) conducted by the National Administrative Department of Statistics (DANE) in Colombia. The dataset spans 1998-2019 and contains 175,914 observations, covering approximately 7,000 manufacturing firms per year. The EAM is a census of medium and large manufacturing establishments and provides detailed and standardized information on firms' production, input use, employment composition, and financial accounts.

The data are organized as an unbalanced panel, reflecting firm entry and exit over time. Following DANE's technical guidelines, the sample is restricted to firms with at least 10 employees, which ensures consistency in reporting standards and improves the reliability of firm-level measures. Observations with missing or implausible values (e.g., negative output or extreme input ratios) are excluded (0.2% of total observations). The data are inspected for outliers to ensure consistency with economic magnitudes.

The main outcome variable is the firm-level markdown, defined as the wedge between the marginal product of labor and the wage paid by the firm. Markdown estimates are obtained from a production function framework that combines estimated output elasticities with observed input shares; the construction is described in detail in the economic theory section.

The dataset provides the necessary information to construct standard production inputs

using the methodology by De Loecker et al., 2020. Labor is measured as total employment, defined as the sum of permanent employees, firm owners, and temporary workers, both directly hired and outsourced. Capital is proxied by the book value of fixed assets, while the wage bill corresponds to total remuneration paid to permanent and temporary employees. Materials are measured as total expenditure on raw materials, intermediate inputs, and packaging, and are treated as the flexible input in production which allows to control for unobservables (Levinsohn and Petrin, 2003). Gross output is proxied by firm-level total sales at factory's price without direct taxes as reported in the survey.

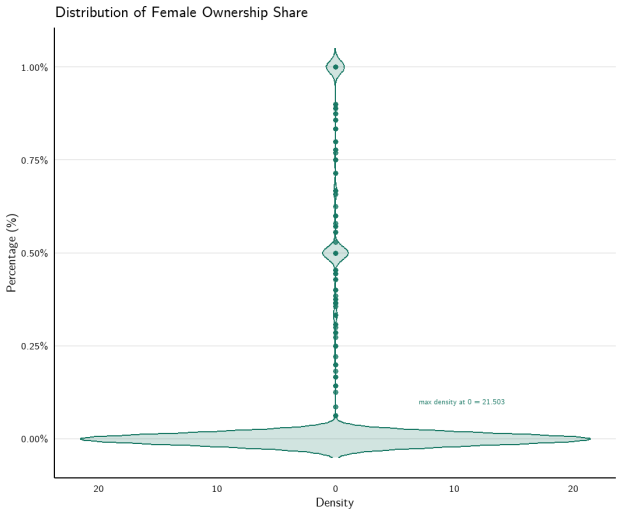
All monetary variables are expressed in nominal Colombian pesos. The empirical analysis relies primarily on ratios and input shares constructed from these variables, which mitigates concerns related to price-level variation. In addition, the dynamic structure of the production function estimation implies that rescaling variables through deflation would not materially affect the estimation of key parameters.

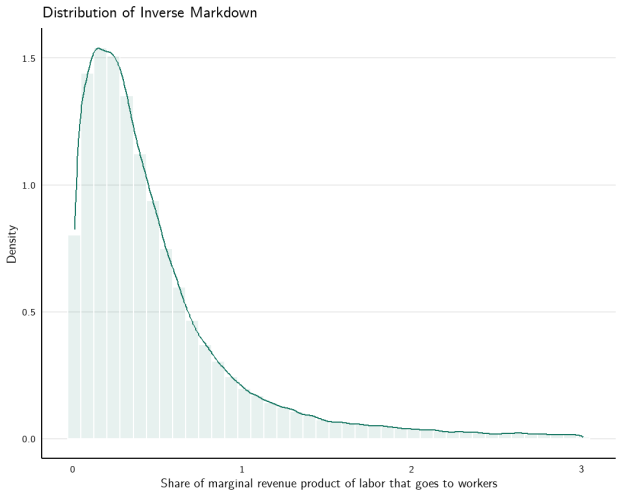
The main explanatory variable is the share of female ownership at the firm level. This measure is constructed using variables C4R1C1-C4R1C5, which report the number of firm owners (*owners, partners, and unpaid family members*) disaggregated by gender and worker type (white-collar and blue-collar). The female ownership share is defined as:

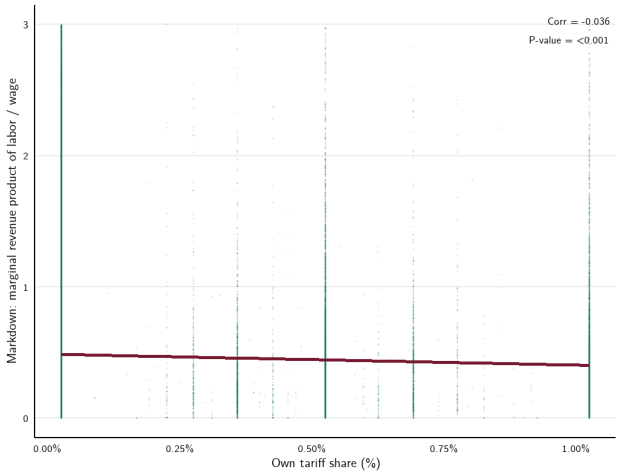
$$\text{Female Ownership Share}_{it} = \frac{\text{Number of female owners}_{it}}{\text{Total number of owners}_{it}}. \tag{20}$$

This variable ranges from 0 to 1 and captures the gender composition of firm ownership. Ownership is measured annually and may vary over time; firms with zero reported owners are excluded.

Finally, the dataset includes detailed identifiers for industry (sector) and geographic location (region), which are used to control for heterogeneity in production technologies, input markets, and regional economic conditions.


Distribution of Female Ownership Share
1.00%
0.75%
0.50%
0.25%
0.00%
Percentage (%)
max density at 0 = 21.503
20
10
0
10
20
Density


Distribution of Inverse Markdown
1.5
1.0
0.5
0.0
Density
0
1
2
3
Share of marginal revenue product of labor that goes to workers


Corr = -0.036
P-value = <0.001
3
2
1
0
Markdown: marginal revenue product of labor / wage
0.00%
0.25%
0.50%
0.75%
1.00%
Own tariff share (%)

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